

environment for the bard of this later age is not unlike that of his predecessors in the great days of Mycenae.

Most important for the appreciation of the cumulative nature of the growth of the legends is the realization that there were two major periods of creative impetus, one before the destruction of Mycenaean civilization and one after. The Homeric poems maintain the fact and fiction of the Bronze Age, but they also portray their own Age of Iron. To mention but one example, archaeology shows us that burial was prevalent in the Mycenaean Age, but in Homer cremation is common. The saga of the Argonauts reflects an interest in the Black Sea that is historical—but was this interest Mycenaean, or do the details belong to the later age of Greek colonization (ca. 800–600 B.C.)? The legend as we have it must be a composite product of both eras. The Theseus story blends, in splendid confusion, Minoan-Mycenaean elements with facts of the later historical period of monarchy in Athens.

The Homeric poems were eventually set down in writing; this was made possible by the invention of an alphabet in the eighth century B.C.¹⁷ The Greeks borrowed the symbols of the Phoenician script and used them to create a true alphabet, distinguishing by each sign individual vowels and consonants, unlike earlier scripts (such as Linear B) in which syllables are the only linguistic units. This stroke of genius, by the way, is typically Greek in its brilliant and inventive simplicity; surely no one of our countless debts to Greek civilization is more fundamental. Is the invention of the Greek alphabet and the setting down of the Homeric epics coincidental? Presumably, the dactylic hexameter of epic poetry cannot be reproduced in the clumsy symbols of Linear B. At any rate, when tradition tells us that the legendary Cadmus of Thebes taught the natives to write, we assume that he instructed them in Mycenaean Linear B rather than in the later Greek alphabet.

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Notes

1. Emily Vermeule, *Greece in the Bronze Age* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1964), offers a survey (now out of date) that contains important earlier bibliography. Vermeule regrettably ignores Homer as evidence; fortunately, however, many archaeologists today have returned to Homer cautiously with important results. See note 15 for Fitton's more recent survey.
2. Schliemann's life and career are the material for a bizarre and exciting success story. He amassed a fortune so that he could prove the validity of his convictions, which he

pursued with passion. Earlier biographies tend to be romantically sympathetic: Emil Ludwig, *Schliemann: The Story of a Gold-Seeker* (Boston: Little, Brown, 1931); Robert Payne, *The Gold of Troy* (New York: Funk and Wagnalls, 1959); Lynn and Gray Poole, *One Passion, Two Loves* (New York: Thomas Y. Crowell, 1966); and Irving Stone, *The Greek Treasure* (New York: Doubleday, 1975). More recently, Schliemann has been characterized as a liar and a fraud: David A. Traill, *Schliemann of Troy: Treasure and Deceit* (New York: St. Martin's Press, 1995). Less scholarly, but nevertheless critical and more balanced, is the biography by Caroline Moorehead: *Lost and Found: The 9,000 Treasures of Troy: Heinrich Schliemann and the Gold That Got Away* (New York: Viking Press, 1996 [1994]). Susan Heuck Allen, *Finding the Walls of Troy* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1999), another detractor, argues that Schliemann obscured his debts to the British archaeologist Frank Calvert for the identification and excavation of the mound of Hisarlik as the site of Troy.

3. See the bibliography for Iconography, Religion, and Feminist Interpretations in Chapter 1, p. 33.
4. The dates for these periods are serviceable. It is rash to insist on greater precision for this early period, for the evidence for it fluctuates daily. The chronology of the Bronze Age is a subject of passionate dispute. Thus, attempts at a more precise chronology with further subdivisions within the periods are not reproduced here. For a scholarly treatment, consult pertinent chapters and charts in *The Cambridge Ancient History*, 3d ed., vol. 2, pt. 1, *The Middle East and the Aegean Region 1800–1380 B.C.*, edited by I. E. S. Edwards, N. G. L. Hammond, and E. Sollberger (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1973); and pt. 2, *The Middle East and the Aegean Region c. 1380–1000 B.C.* (1975).
5. For a more detailed interpretation of the evidence in terms of Minoan-Mycenaean religion, see W. K. C. Guthrie, "The Religion and Mythology of the Greeks," in Edwards et al., eds., *The Cambridge Ancient History*, vol. 2, pt. 2, Chapter 40.
6. For a survey of the excavations at Thera, the relationship to Crete, and theories about Atlantis, see Christos G. Doulas, *Thera: Pompeii of the Ancient Aegean* (London: Thames & Hudson, 1983).
7. Some believe that a later wave of invaders (ca. 1600 B.C.) is to be specifically identified as the Achaeans in Homer; it is better to consider Achaeans as virtually an equivalent term for the Mycenaean Greeks.
8. Linear A tablets (Linear B is derived from the Linear A script), found on Crete, have not yet been deciphered; apparently Minoan Linear A is not Greek. Linear B tablets (written in an early form of Greek) have also been found at Cnossus, with provocative implications for historical reconstruction. Hostile criticism of Evans is offered by Leonard R. Palmer, *Mycenaeans and Minoans*, 2d ed. (New York: Knopf, 1965).
9. John Chadwick, *The Decipherment of Linear B*, 2d ed. (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1958).
10. Blegen's results have been published in a series of highly technical volumes. Like the reports of his excavations at Pylos, they are a monumental testimony to the scientific precision of modern archaeological procedures. Blegen has provided a survey of the excavations at Troy for the general reader: Carl W. Blegen, *Troy and the Trojans* (New York: Praeger, 1963). We are grateful to Manfred Korfmann, C. Brian Rose, and Getzel Cohen for information about the new excavations of Troy.
11. The official catalogue of the "Gold of Troy" exhibition at the Pushkin State Museum of Fine Arts, Moscow (with beautiful color illustrations), has been published: Vladimir Tolstikov and Mikhail Treister, *The Gold of Troy: Searching for Homer's Fabled City*. Translated from the Russian by Christina Sever and Mila Bonnicksen (New York: Harry N. Abrams, 1996).
12. Details and quotations about the excavations come from the *Newsletters of the Friends of Troy*, offered by the Institute for Mediterranean Studies in Cincinnati. This information has been updated, with the most recent material from Joachim Latacz, *Troy and Homer: Towards a Solution of an Old Mystery*. Translated by Kevin Windle and Rosh

Ireland (New York: Oxford University Press, 2004). Latacz, a friend and colleague of Manfred Korfmann (director of the excavations until his death in 2005), presents the most recent survey (the first edition, 2001, has been revised and expanded). Scholarly annual excavation reports appear in *Studia Troica* (Mainz, Germany: Verlag Philipp von Zabern), published in both German and English, which also includes interdisciplinary research concerning Troy.

13. A second ditch found over 100 meters south of and in front of the first ditch offered another, preliminary obstacle, perhaps against chariot attacks. It is unknown if this measure of redoubled security was backed by a wall.
14. Constantino Baikouzis and Marcelo O. Magnasco. "Is an Eclipse Described in the Odyssey?" *Proceedings of the National Academy of Science*, 105, no. 26 (July 2008), pp. 8823–8828.
15. J. Lesley Fitton, in her survey of Bronze Age archaeology, *The Discovery of the Greek Bronze Age* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1996), sensibly observes (p. 203): "It seems a sad decline to our modern recognition that the material remains of a pre-literate society, incompletely recovered, can properly be expected only to answer limited and impersonal questions." Nevertheless, she concludes (p. 197) that "Without writing, 'proof' [of the Trojan War] is well nigh unimaginable."
16. See Carl W. Blegen, *Troy and the Trojans* (New York: Praeger, 1963), p. 20.
17. The argument for connecting Homer with the invention of the alphabet has been cogently made by H. T. Wade-Gery, *The Poet of the Iliad* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1952). See also Barry B. Powell, *Homer and the Origins of the Greek Alphabet* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1991).

Myths of Creation

Now the whole of heaven (uranus)—or let us call it the universe (cosmos) or some other name that it would prefer—regarding it we must consider first that question underlying every investigation which must be sought at the outset. Has it always existed, with no origin from generation, or has it come into being, arising out of some beginning?

—PLATO, *Timaeus* 28b



THERE WERE MANY MYTHS about creation among the Greeks and Romans, and these myths have many parallels in other mythologies, such as Egyptian, Sumerian, Babylonian, and Hebraic. Homer (ca. 800 B.C.) has the Titans Oceanus and Tethys (identified later in this chapter) responsible for the origin of the gods (*Iliad* 14. 201) and reflects a primitive belief that the universe can be understood in terms of a simple geography. The world is a flat disc with hills, touched at its rim by the vast dome of the heavens. The deity Oceanus is the stream of ocean that encircles the earth (see figure on p. 619). But Homer does not by any means provide a complete account of genesis. Hesiod (ca. 700 B.C.), as far as we can tell, was the first to give literary expression to a systematic explanation of how the gods, the universe, and humankind came into being. At any rate his account, the earliest to survive, may be considered the classic Greek version. The genealogical scheme is presented in his *Theogony*, while his *Works and Days* adds significant details.

Hesiod

In the opening of the *Theogony*, Hesiod devotes many lines to the beauty and power of the **Muses**, with particular emphasis on their ability to inspire the infallible revelation of the poet. He lovingly describes their graceful dancing and exquisite singing to delight the gods on Olympus. This ardent invocation to the Muses is no mere artistic convention but rather the utterance of a prophetic visionary. Since the Muses are the daughters of Zeus, their revelation comes from the infallible knowledge



Audio

of the supreme god. Hesiod's vehement sincerity may be illustrated by these lines from the *Theogony* (22–34):

They, the Muses, once taught Hesiod beautiful song, while he was shepherding his flocks on holy Mount Helicon; these goddesses of Olympus, daughters of aegis-bearing Zeus first of all spoke this word to me, "Oh, you shepherds of the fields, base and lowly things, little more than bellies, we know how to tell many falsehoods that seem like truths but we also know, when we so desire, how to utter the absolute truth." (22–28)

Thus they spoke, the fluent daughters of great Zeus. Plucking a branch, to me they gave a staff of laurel, a wondrous thing, and into me they breathed a divine voice, so that I might celebrate both the things that are to be and the things that were before; and they ordered me to honor, in my song, the race of the blessed gods who exist forever, but always to sing of them themselves, the Muses, both first and last. (29–31) 10

Hesiod's attention to the Muses is steeped in a religious aura of divinely inspired revelation. As he begins his genesis, Hesiod asks the Muses, "Tell me how first gods, earth, rivers, the boundless sea . . . the shining stars, and the wide heavens above came into being." This is their answer (*Theogony* 116–125):

Verily, very first of all Chaos came into being, but then wide-bosomed Gaia, secure foundation of all forever, and dark Tartarus in the depth of the broad land and Eros, the most beautiful of all the immortal gods, who loosens the limbs and overwhelms judgment and wise counsel in the breast of gods and all humans. From Chaos, Erebus [the gloom of Tartarus] and black Night came into being; but from Night were born Aether [the upper atmosphere] and Day, whom Night bore when she became pregnant after mingling in love with Erebus.

The Greek word *Chaos* suggests a "yawning void." Exactly what it means to Hesiod, however, is difficult to establish.¹ His account of creation, fraught with problems, begins paratactically; that is, very first of all **Chaos** (not a deity particularly, but a beginning or a first principle, perhaps a void) came into being (or was), but then (next) came **Gaia** (**Gaea** or **Ge**, Earth)² and the others. All presumably came out of Chaos, just as Hesiod actually states, as he continues, that "from Chaos" came Erebus and dark Night. **Tartarus** is a place deep in the depths of the earth (*Theogony* 713 ff.); **Erebus** is the gloomy darkness of Tartarus; later it may be equated with Tartarus itself.

The scholarly (sometimes adamant) disagreement that surrounds this passage concerns the interpretation of "then" (i.e., "next"). Do Gaea, Tartarus, and Eros emerge next after Chaos or through generation out of Chaos? It is our conviction that all three arose out of Chaos, as indicated in Figure 3.1 (cf. Ovid's description of Chaos as the primal source of creation, discussed on p. 62).

The Primacy and Mystery of Eros

Love, typically a potent force in tales of creation and procreation, inevitably appears early in the *Theogony*. Hesiod, as we have just seen, describes the most beautiful Eros by one of his characteristically brief touches, which strive to lift his didacticism to the realm of poetry. For the Romans, Eros was called Cupid (or Amor).

Hesiod

The poet Hesiod has a much greater identity than his predecessor Homer, who is more immediately linked to an oral tradition and belongs to the coast of Asia Minor or the adjacent islands. Dates for Hesiod are in much dispute, but he probably composed his two poems, the *Theogony* and *Works and Days*, around 700. Which work was written first also is uncertain, and other works (e.g., the *Catalogs of Women and Heroines* and *Divination by Birds*) are only dubiously to be attributed to him. Certainly, the *Shield of Heracles* belongs to a later period.

As we have seen, in the *Theogony* Hesiod provides some information about his life. More details are to be found in his *Works and Days*, a didactic poem about farming incorporating important mythological stories, which are excerpted in the next chapter. From these two poems, the following biographical sketch may be drawn. Of course, how much of it is true or false, irrefutable fact or fictional literary artifice, is extremely debatable.

Hesiod's father came from Cyme, situated in the larger area of Aeolis in Asia Minor. He eventually crossed the Aegean and settled in Ascra, a town near Mt. Helicon, in Boeotia, where Hesiod was born and lived his life and which he describes with his usual dour outlook as "bad in winter, difficult in summer, and never good at all" (*Works and Days* 640). Hesiod had a son, so we must assume that he got married. Misanthrope that he is, Hesiod still recommends a good marriage, if it can be found. Perhaps he was embittered by his experiences with his wife—an idle conjecture! He does tell us for a fact that his embitterment stems from his brother Perses' betrayal of him.

After the death of their father, Hesiod had a serious dispute with Perses over their inheritance. The case was brought before a court, and the judges, who were bribed by Perses, cheated Hesiod of his fair share. Hesiod composed the *Works and Days* as an admonition to his brother to follow the path of justice and obey the righteous dictates of the one god, Zeus. The *Theogony*, too, is drenched in a similar religious fervor, describing the genesis of the world, mortals, and the gods and tracing the momentous events that led to the supremacy of Zeus.

Hesiod grew up as a farmer and a shepherd and became a poet. He once sailed to Chalcis on the island of Euboea, and there, at the funeral games of Amphidamas, he won the first prize in the poetry contest, a tripod. He dedicated the tripod to the Muses at the very spot on Mt. Helicon where he had received their divine inspiration.

Another myth of creation is found in the *Birds*, a comedy by the playwright Aristophanes (fifth century B.C.). For all its mock heroism and burlesque of religious and philosophical speculation, this account reflects earlier theory and illustrates both the multiplicity of versions and the primacy of Eros. A chorus of birds proves that the birds are much the oldest of all the gods by the following tale (693–702):

Chaos, Night, black Erebus, and broad Tartarus were first. But Ge, Aer [the lower atmosphere], and Uranus [Sky] did not exist. In the vast hollows of Erebus first of all black-winged Night, alone, brought forth an egg, from which Eros, the desirable, burst forth like a swift whirlwind, his back glistening with golden wings. He mingled in broad Tartarus with Chaos, winged and

dark as night, and hatched our race of birds and first led it to light. There was no race of immortals before Eros caused all things to mingle. From the mingling of couples, Uranus, Oceanus, Ge, and the immortal race of all the blessed gods came into being.

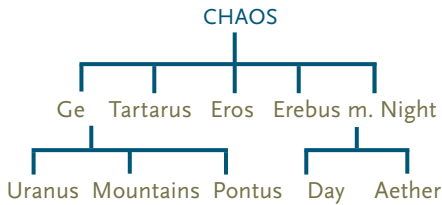


Figure 3.1. Descendants of Chaos

The Eros responsible for this fury of procreation may very well be the same Eros who, in the later tradition, is appropriately called Phanes (the one who first shone forth or gave light to creation) and Protogonus (first-born). If so, we have in Aristophanes a parody of a myth that was the basis of a religion ascribed to Orpheus in which the world-egg was a dominant symbol. Orpheus and Orphism are discussed in Chapter 16, and with them other religions similar in nature, designated generically as mystery religions.³ The link between myth and profound religious thought and experience in the ancient world is a continuing and fascinating theme.

Creation According to Ovid

Ovid, a Roman poet who wrote some 700 years after Hesiod, provides another classic account of genesis, different in important respects from that of Hesiod. Ovid is eclectic in his sources, which include not only Hesiod but many other writers, in particular, Empedocles, a fifth-century philosopher, who theorized that four basic elements (earth, air, fire, and water) are the primary materials of the universe.

Ovid's Chaos (*Metamorphoses* 1. 1–75) is not a gaping void but rather a crude and unformed mass of elements in strife, from which a god (not named) or some higher nature formed the order of the universe.⁴ Ovid's poem *Metamorphoses*, which concentrates on stories that involve transformations of various sorts, could very well provide a basic text for a survey of mythology. We shall on occasion reproduce Ovid's versions, since it is often his poetic, sensitive, sophisticated, and at times ironic treatment that has dominated subsequent tradition. But we must remember that Ovid is Roman, and late, and that his mythology is far removed in spirit and belief from that of earlier conceptions. Mythology for him is little more than inspirational, poetic fodder, however successful and attractive the end product may be. Both the poetic and the real worlds of Hesiod and Ovid are poles apart.

The Sacred Marriage of Uranus (Sky) and Gaia (Ge, Earth) and Their Offspring

But let us return to Hesiod's *Theogony* (126–156):

Gaia first brought forth starry Uranus, equal to herself, so that he might surround and cover her completely and be a secure home for the blessed gods forever. And she brought forth the lofty mountain ranges, charming haunts of the divine nymphs who inhabit the hills and dales. And she also bore, without the sweet union of love, Pontus, the barren deep, with its raging surf. (126–132)

But then Gaia lay with Uranus and bore the deep-eddyng Oceanus, and [the Titans, namely] Coeus, and Crius, and Hyperion, and Iapetus, and Theia, and Rhea, and Themis, and Mnemosyne, and golden-crowned Thebe, and lovely Tethys. After them, she brought forth wily Cronus, the youngest and most terrible of her children and he hated his lusty father. (132–138) 10

Moreover, she bore the **Cyclopes**, insolent at heart, Brontes (“Thunder”) and Steropes (“Lightning”) and bold Arges (“Bright”), who fashioned and gave to Zeus his bolt of thunder and lightning. They had only one eye, set in the middle of their foreheads but they were like the gods in all other respects. They were given the name Cyclopes (“Orb-eyed”) because one single round eye was set in their foreheads.⁵ Might and power and skill were in their works. (139–146)

In turn, Gaia and Uranus were the parents of three other sons, great and unspeakably violent, Cottus, Briareus, and Gyes, arrogant children. A hundred invincible arms and hands sprang out of their shoulders and also from out of their shoulders there grew fifty heads, all supported by their strong limbs. Invincible was the powerful strength in these mighty hulks. Of all the children that Gaia and Uranus produced these were the most terrible and they were hated by their father from the very first. (147–156) 20

For Hesiod, it appears, the first deity is female, a basic, matriarchical concept of Mother Earth and her fertility as primary and divine; comparative studies of iconography from primitive societies provide abundant evidence to confirm this archetype of the primacy of the feminine.⁶ The male sky-god Uranus (another fundamental conception), produced by Earth herself, emerges, at least in this version, as her equal partner. In matriarchal societies, he is reduced to a subordinate; in patriarchal societies, he becomes the supreme god.

So it is, then, that the personification and deification of sky and earth as Uranus and Ge (Gaia) and their physical union represent basic recurring themes in mythology. Uranus is the male principle, a god of the sky, whereas Ge is the female goddess of fertility and the earth. Worship of them may be traced back to very early times; sky and rain, earth and fertility are fundamental concerns and sources of wonder to “primitive” agricultural peoples. The rain of Uranus might, for example, be imagined as his seed that fertilizes the hungry earth and makes her conceive. Thus develops the archetypal concept of a “sacred” or “holy marriage,” a translation of the Greek phrase **hieros gamos**. The sky-god and the earth-goddess appear again and again under various names and guises (for example, Uranus and Ge, Cronus and Rhea, and Zeus and Hera) to enact this holy rite.

The worship of the female earth divinity was widespread and diverse, whether or not she assumed the dominant role in the partnership with her male consort. But whatever her name and however varied her worship, she is significant in all periods, either maintaining her own identity or lurking behind, influencing, and coloring more complex and sophisticated concepts of female deity. Ge, Themis, Cybele, Rhea, Hera, Demeter, and Aphrodite are all, either wholly or

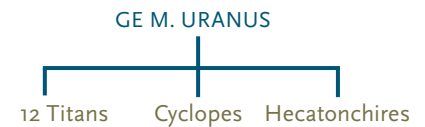


Figure 3.2. Children of Ge and Uranus

“For Dust Thou Art, and unto Dust Shalt Thou Return” (Genesis 3.19)

A Chorus from the lost play of Euripides, *Chrysippus* (fragment 839, Loeb), reads as follows:⁷

Earth, the greatest, and the Aether of Zeus, he who begets human beings and gods and she who receives his moist, nurturing drops and bears mortals, bears vegetation and the families of animals. Therefore she is justly esteemed mother of all. Whatever is born from earth returns to earth but whatever springs from the ethereal seed returns to the vault of heaven. Nothing that has come into being perishes but one is separated from another and exhibits a different form.

In the first line, Aether (the realm of Zeus) and Zeus are essentially one, so that “he” can be interpreted as the rain of Zeus, whose drops fertilize earth. This conception of Zeus as our heavenly father who has given us an immortal soul and Earth, our mother, who is the source of our mortality reflects the mythology of Hesiod and the subsequent development of its profound implications in the sixth and fifth centuries B.C. The succinct and tantalizing utterance of this Chorus about a subject that soon became a major philosophical and religious theme of enormous import was much quoted and its meaning variously interpreted.

in part, divinities of fertility.⁸ Certainly, the emotional, philosophical, religious, and intellectual range of the worship of the mother-goddess is vast. It may run the gamut from frenzied orgiastic celebrations, with the castration of her devoted priests, to a sublime belief in spiritual communion and personal redemption; and from a blatant emphasis on the sexual attributes and potency of the female to an idealized vision of love, motherhood, and virgin birth.⁹

The *Homeric Hymn to Earth, Mother of All* (30), in its invocation of Gaia (Ge), gives us the essentials of her primary archetype:

About Earth, I will sing, all-mother, deep-rooted and eldest, who nourishes all that there is in the world: all that go on the divine land, all that sail on the sea and all that fly—these she nourishes from her bounty. From you, reverend lady, mortal humans have abundance in children and in crops, and it is up to you to give them their livelihood or take it away. Rich and fortunate are those whom you honor with your kind support. To them all things are abundant, their fields are laden with produce, their pastures are covered with herds and flocks, and their homes are filled with plenty. These rule with good laws in cities of beautiful women and much happiness and wealth attend them. Their sons glory in exuberant joy and their daughters, with carefree hearts, play in blossom-laden choruses and dance on the grass over the soft flowers. These are the fortunate whom you honor, holy goddess, bountiful deity. (1–16)

Hail, mother of the gods, wife of starry Uranus. Kindly grant happy sustenance in return for my song and I will remember both you and another song too. (17–19)

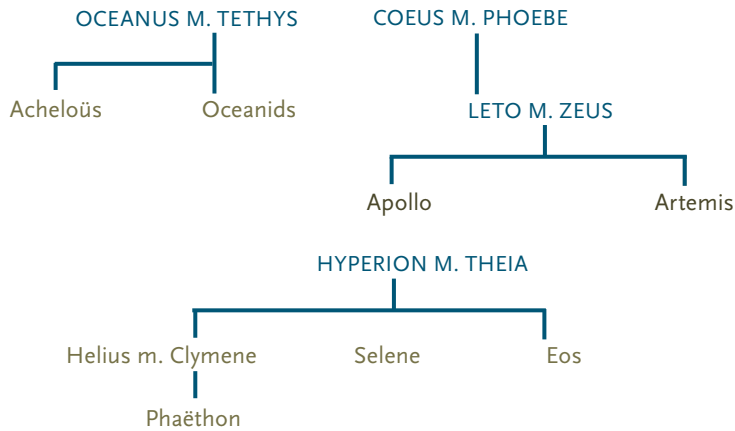


Figure 3.3. Descendants of the Titans

Helius. Red-figure krater by the Darius painter, ca. 330 B.C. Height 13 in. Helius, his head encircled by rays, drives his chariot upward out of the sea. He holds the reins to guide four winged horses. On the extreme left (above the handle) a boy has dived into the sea (his feet are at the top); a second boy stands at the bottom left on a rock, preparing to dive; to his right a third is in midflight as he dives in; a fourth, at the bottom center, is already waist deep in the sea, proceeding to the viewer's left but looking back toward Helius and his chariot. A meander design frames the lower edge of the painting, balanced by a laurel wreath round the upper edge. (© The Trustees of the British Museum)



The Titans and Their Descendants: Ocean, Sun, Moon, and Dawn

The Titans, children of Uranus and Ge, are twelve in number: Oceanus, Coeus, Crius, Hyperion, Iapetus, Theia, Rhea, Themis, Mnemosyne, Phoebe, Tethys, and “wily Cronus, the youngest and most terrible of these children and he hated his lusty father” (*Theogony* 137–138). They are for the most part deifications of various aspects of nature, and they are important for their progeny, although a few assume some significance in themselves. In the genealogical labyrinth of mythology, all lineage may be traced back to the Titans and to the other powers originating from Chaos. From these beginnings Hesiod creates a universe both real and imagined, physical and spiritual, peopled with gods, demigods, deified or personified abstractions, animals, monsters, and mortals; we cannot list them all here, but we shall select the most important figures. The Titans are best considered in pairs, since there are six males and six females; and the inevitable, incestuous matings of some of these brothers and sisters produce cosmic progeny.

Oceanus and the Oceanids

Oceanus and his mate, Tethys, produced numerous children, the Oceanids, three thousand daughters, and the same number of sons, spirits of rivers, waters, and

springs, many with names and some with mythological personalities.¹⁰ Hesiod provides an impressive list, but he admits (*Theogony* 369–370) that it is difficult for a mortal to name them all, although people know those belonging to their own area.

Hyperion and Helius, Gods of the Sun

The Titan Hyperion is a god of the sun, more important than his sister and mate, Theia. They are the parents of Helius, Selene, and Eos. Helius, like his father, is a sun-god. Duplication of divinities is common in the early scheme of things; they may exist side by side, or their names and personalities may be confused. Very often the younger generation will dominate the older and usurp its power.

The conventional picture of the sun-god is in harmony with the Homeric conception of geography described at the beginning of this chapter. The sun-god dwells in the East, crosses the dome of the sky with his team of horses, descends in the West into the stream of Oceanus, which encircles the earth, and sails back to the East, chariot and all. The *Homeric Hymn to Helius* (31) offers a glowing picture. Euryphaëssa (the word means “widely shining”), given as the wife of Hyperion and the mother of Helius, is probably just another name for Theia.

Now begin to sing, O Muse Calliope, daughter of Zeus, about shining Helius, whom ox-eyed Euryphaëssa bore to the son of Earth and starry Uranus. For Hyperion married glorious Euryphaëssa, his own sister, who bore him beautiful children: rosy-fingered Eos and Selene of the lovely hair and weariless Helius like the deathless ones, who shines for mortals and immortal gods as he drives his horses. The piercing gaze of his eyes flashes out of his golden helmet. Bright beams radiate brilliantly from his temples and the shining hair of his head frames a gracious countenance seen from afar. The exquisite, finely wrought robe that clothes his body shimmers in the blast of the winds. Mighty stallions are under his control. Then he stays his golden-yoked chariot and horses and stops there at the peak of the heavens, until the time when he again miraculously drives them down through the sky to the Ocean. (1–16)

Hail, lord, kindly grant a happy sustenance. From you I have begun and I shall go on to celebrate the race of mortal men, the demigods, whose achievements the Muses have revealed to mortals. (17–19)

Phaëthon, Son of Helius

A well-known story concerns Phaëthon (whose name means “shining”), the son of Helius by one of his mistresses, Clymene. According to Ovid’s account (*Metamorphoses* 1. 747–779; 2. 1–366), Phaëthon was challenged by the accusation that the Sun was not his real father at all. His mother, Clymene, however, swore to him that he was truly the child of Helius and told him that he should, if he so desired, ask his father, the sun-god himself.

Ovid beautifully describes the magnificent palace of the Sun, with its towering columns, gleaming with gold and polished ivory. Phaëthon, awed by the grandeur, is prevented from coming too close to the god because of his radiance; Helios, however, confirms Clymene's account of Phaëthon's parentage, lays aside the rays that shine around his head, and orders his son to approach. He embraces him and promises, on an oath sworn by the Styx (dread river of the Underworld), that the boy may have any gift he likes so that he may dispel his doubts once and for all. Phaëthon quickly and decisively asks that he be allowed to drive his father's chariot for one day.

Helios tries in vain to dissuade Phaëthon, but he must abide by his dread oath. He reluctantly leads the youth to his chariot, fashioned exquisitely by Vulcan,¹¹ of gold, silver, and jewels that reflect the brilliant light of the god. The chariot is yoked; Helios anoints his son's face as protection against the flames, places the rays on his head, and with heavy heart advises him on his course and the management of the horses.

Phaëthon, young and inexperienced, is unable to control the four-winged horses who speed from their usual path. The chariot races to the heights of heaven, creating havoc by the intensity of the heat, then hurtles down to earth. Ovid delights in his description of the destruction; among the many transformations that result because of the heat, the Ethiopians at this time acquired their dark skins and Libya became a desert. Earth herself is ablaze and unable to endure her fiery anguish any longer.

Jupiter, in answer to Earth's prayer, hurls his thunder and lightning and shatters the car, dashing Phaëthon to his death. The river Eridanus receives and bathes him, and nymphs bury him with the following inscription upon his tomb: "Here is buried Phaëthon, charioteer of his father's car; he could not control it, yet he died after daring great deeds."¹²

Other Loves of Helios

Helios also loved the Eastern princess Leucothoë, daughter of the Persian king Orchamus. Disguising himself as Eurynome, her mother, he seduced her.

Another of the lovers of Helios, the Oceanid Clytië, jealous because Helios preferred Leucothoë to her, told Leucothoë's father of the affair. Orchamus buried Leucothoë, and Helios was too late to save her. He shed drops of nectar on her corpse, which grew into a frankincense tree. Clytië could not persuade Helios to forgive her, nor could she recover his love. She sat, following the Sun's progress with her eyes until she turned into a sunflower, which forever turns its face toward the sun.

The island of Rhodes was sacred to Helios, the Sun. When Zeus was dividing up the lands of the world among the gods, Rhodes had not yet appeared above the surface of the sea. Helios was accidentally not given a share, but he refused Zeus' offer of a redivision, for he could see the future island below the sea, and he took it as his possession when it appeared. There he loved the island's nymph Rhode, and one of her seven sons became the father of the heroes of the three principal cities of Rhodes, Camirus, Ialysus, and Lindos. Even late in historical times, the people of Rhodes threw a chariot and four horses into the sea every October as a replacement for the old chariot and horses of the sun that would be worn out after the labors of the summer.¹³

Selene, Goddess of the Moon, and Endymion

Selene, daughter of Hyperion and Theia, is a goddess of the moon. Like her brother Helios, she drives a chariot, although hers usually has only two horses. The *Homeric Hymn to Selene* (32) presents a picture.

Tell in song about the moon in her long-winged flight, Muses, skilled in song, sweet-voiced daughters of Zeus, the son of Cronus. The heavenly gleam from her immortal head radiates onto earth. The vast beauty of the cosmos emerges under her shining radiance. The air, unlit before, glistens and the rays from her golden crown offer illumination whenever divine Selene, having bathed her beautiful skin, puts on her far-glistening raiment, and yokes the powerful necks of her shining team, and drives her beautifully maned horses at full speed in the evening; in mid-month brightest are her beams as she waxes and her great orbit is full. From the heavens she is fixed as a sure sign for mortals. (1–13)

10

Once Zeus, the son of Cronus, joined in loving union with her; she became pregnant and bore a daughter, Pandia, who had exceptional loveliness among the immortal gods. (14–16)

Hail, kind queen with beautiful hair, white-armed goddess, divine Selene. From you I have begun and I shall go on to sing of mortal demigods whose achievements minstrels, servants of the Muses, celebrate in songs from loving lips. (17–20)

Only one famous myth is linked with Selene, and that concerns her love for the handsome youth Endymion, who is usually depicted as a shepherd. On a still night, Selene saw Endymion asleep in a cave on Mt. Latmus (in Caria). Night after night, she lay down beside him as he slept. There are many variants to this story, but in all the outcome is the same: Zeus grants Endymion perpetual sleep with perpetual youth. This may be represented as a punishment (although sometimes Endymion is given some choice) because of Selene's continual absence from her duties in the heavens, or it may be the fulfillment of Selene's own wishes for her beloved.

Apollo, Sun-God, and Artemis, Moon-Goddess

Many stories about the god of the sun, whether he be called Hyperion, Helios, or merely the Titan, were transferred to the great god Apollo, who shares with them the same epithet, **Phoebus**, which means “bright.” Although Apollo was, in all probability, not originally a sun-god, he came to be considered as such. Thus, Phaëthon may become the son of Apollo, as sun-god. Similarly Apollo's twin sister Artemis became associated with the moon, although originally she probably was not a moon-goddess. Thus, Selene and Artemis merge in identity, just as do Hyperion, Helios, and Apollo; and Selene and Artemis also are described by the adjective “bright,” **Phoebe** (the feminine form of Phoebus).¹⁴ Therefore, the lover of Endymion becomes Artemis (or Roman Diana).



The Endymion Sarcophagus. Marble, ca. A.D. 200–220; width 73 in., height 28 in (with lid). The sarcophagus is shaped like a trough in which grapes were pressed. On the lid is a portrait of its occupant, Arria, with nine reliefs: those on the extreme left and right are of mountain gods, appropriate to the setting of the myth on Mt. Latmos; the next pair represents the seasons, Autumn on the left and Spring on the right; the next pair are Cupid and Psyche on the left and Aphrodite and Eros on the right; the next pair are Ares on the left and his lover, Aphrodite, on the right. Balancing Arria is the union of Selene and Endymion. In the center of the main panel, Selene descends from her chariot, whose horses are held by a nymph, to join Endymion, who lies to the right. Night pours the opiate of sleep over him (note the poppy-head between the heads of Night and the lion) and Cupids play around the lovers and beneath the right lion's head. Cupid and Psyche embrace beneath the left lion's head. Oceanus and Ge, respectively, lie to the left and beneath Selene's horses, and the horses of the chariot of Helius can be seen rising at the left, while Selene's chariot disappears to the right. The myth of Endymion was a common subject for Roman sarcophagi (seventy examples are known from the second and third centuries A.D.) because it gave hope that the sleep of death would lead to eternal life. (Image copyright © The Metropolitan Museum of Art/Art Resource, NY)



Closer Look

Eos, Goddess of the Dawn, and Tithonus

Eos (the Roman **Aurora**), the third child of Hyperion and Theia, is goddess of the dawn, and like her sister Selene drives a two-horsed chariot. Her epithets in poetry are appropriate: she is called rosy-fingered and saffron-robed. She is an amorous deity. Aphrodite, the goddess of love, caused her to long perpetually for young mortals because she caught her mate Ares in Eos' bed,¹⁵ but her most important mate was Tithonus, a handsome youth of the Trojan royal house. Eos carried off Tithonus; their story is simply and effectively told in the *Homeric Hymn to Aphrodite* (5. 220–238), which is translated in its entirety in Chapter 9.

Eos went to Zeus, the dark-clouded son of Cronus, to ask that Tithonus be immortal and live forever. Zeus nodded his assent and accomplished her wish. Poor goddess, she did not think to ask that her beloved avoid ruinous old age and retain perpetual youth. (220–224)



Aurora, by Guido Reni (1575–1642); 112 × 280 in. Reni painted this work in 1614 for the ceiling of the Casino (pavilion) in the gardens of the palace in Rome of Cardinal Scipione Borghese. Aurora (Eos) precedes Apollo (Helios) as she rolls back the curtain of night and scatters flowers. Apollo drives his four-horse chariot accompanied by the Hours. Above the horses flies a winged putto holding a lighted torch symbolic of the dawn. (Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY)

Indeed, as long as he kept his desirable youthful bloom, Tithonus took his pleasure with early-born Eos of the golden throne by the stream of Oceanus at the ends of the earth. But when the first gray hairs sprouted from his beautiful head and noble chin, Eos avoided his bed. But she kept him in her house and tended him, giving him food, ambrosia, and lovely garments. When hateful old age oppressed him completely and he could not move or raise his limbs, the following plan seemed best to her. She laid him in a room and closed the shining doors. From within his voice flows faintly and he no longer has the strength that he formerly had in his supple limbs. (225–238)

10

These poignant few lines depict simply and powerfully the beauty of youth and the devastation of old age, describe the devotion of love even though sexual attraction has gone, and give a warning to us all: Be careful what you pray for, since God may grant your request. Oscar Wilde puts it more cleverly: “When the gods choose to punish us, they merely answer our prayers.” Later writers add that eventually Tithonus was turned into a grasshopper.

The Castration of Uranus and the Birth of Aphrodite

We must now return to Hesiod (*Theogony* 156–206), and his account of the birth of the mighty goddess of love, Aphrodite (the Roman Venus). As we learned earlier, the children of Uranus and Ge (the twelve Titans, including the last-born, wily

Cronus, who especially hated his father; the Cyclopes; and the Hecatonchires) all were despised by their father from the beginning.

As each of his children was born, Uranus hid them all in the depths of Ge and did not allow them to emerge into the light. And he delighted in his wickedness. But huge Earth in her distress groaned within and devised a crafty and evil scheme. At once she created gray adamant and fashioned a great sickle and confided in her dear children. Sorrowing in her heart, she urged them as follows: "My children born of a presumptuous father, if you are willing to obey, we shall punish his evil insolence. For he was the first to devise shameful actions." (156–166)

Thus she spoke. Fear seized them all and not one answered. But great and wily Cronus took courage and spoke to his dear mother: "I shall undertake and accomplish the deed, since I do not care about our abominable father. For he was the first to devise shameful actions." (167–172) 10

Thus he spoke. And huge Earth rejoiced greatly in her heart. She hid him in an ambush and placed in his hands the sickle with jagged teeth and revealed the whole plot to him. Great Uranus came leading on night, and, desirous of love, lay on Ge, spreading himself over her completely. And his son from his ambush reached out with his left hand and in his right he seized hold of the huge sickle with jagged teeth and swiftly cut off the genitals of his own dear father and threw them so that they fell behind him. And they did not fall from his hand in vain. Earth received all the bloody drops that fell and in the course of the seasons bore the strong Erinyes and the mighty giants (shining in their armor and carrying long spears in their hands) and nymphs of ash trees (called Meliae on the wide earth). (173–187) 20

When first he had cut off the genitals with the adamant and cast them from the land on the swelling sea, they were carried for a long time on the deep. And white foam arose about from the immortal flesh and in it a maiden grew. First she was brought to holy Cythera, and then from there she came to sea-girt Cyprus. And she emerged a dread and beautiful goddess and grass rose under her slender feet. (188–195)

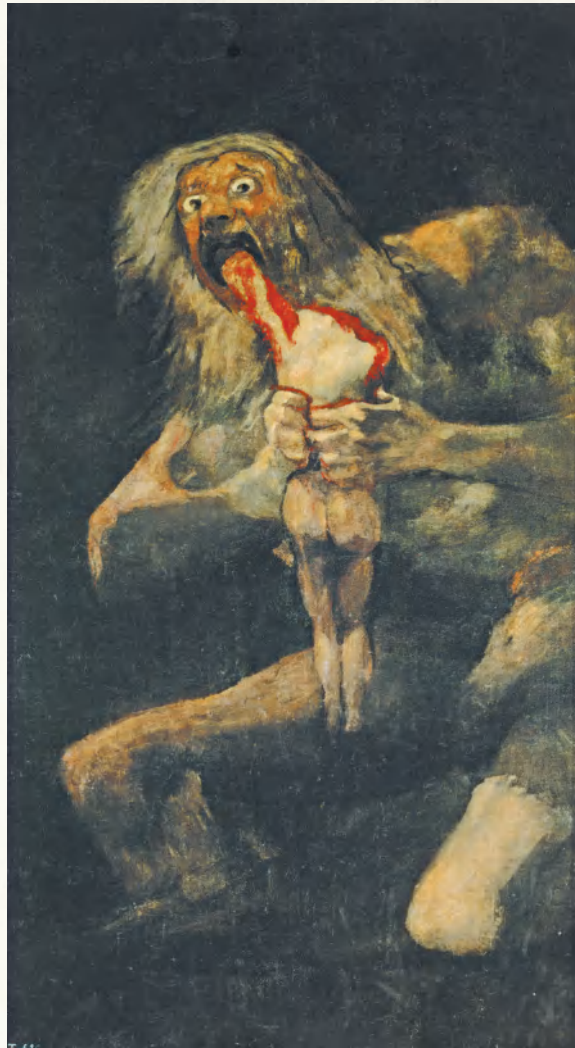
Gods and human beings call her Aphrodite, and the foam-born goddess because she grew amid the foam (*aphros*), and Cytherea of the beautiful crown because she came to Cythera, and Cyprogenes because she arose in Cyprus washed by the waves. She is called too Philommedes (genital-loving) because she arose from the genitals.¹⁶ Eros attended her and beautiful desire followed her when she was born and when she first went into the company of the gods. From the beginning she has this honor, and among human beings and the immortal gods she wins as her due the whispers of girls, smiles, deceits, sweet pleasure, and the gentle delicacy of love. (195–206) 30

The stark power of this passage is felt even in translation. The real, yet anthropomorphic, depiction of the vast earth enveloped sexually by the surrounding sky presents its own kind of poetic power. The transparent illustration of basic motives and forces in human nature, through this brutal allegory of Aphrodite's birth, provides fertile material for modern psychology: the youngest son whose devotion to his mother is used by her against

Saturn Devouring His Children

Francisco Goya was one of the most important Spanish painters of the eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries. The tone of his works darkened with the deteriorating political situation in Spain at the end of the eighteenth century. Spain witnessed the fall of an enlightened monarchy, a devastating invasion by Napoleon in 1808, and the restoration of a monarchy that was oppressive. Savage atrocities suffered during war became one of Goya's major themes, especially as he fell out of court favor and increasingly withdrew from the world. Toward the end of his life, in the seclusion of his country home, he painted on the walls of his retreat a series of dark and disturbing images known collectively as *Las Pinturas Negras* (*The Black Paintings*). *Saturn Devouring His Children* is the most famous of these paintings. The ancient relief depicts Rhea handing the stone to Cronus to be eaten and shows

Saturn Devouring One of His Children, by Francisco Goya y Lucientes (1746–1828); oil on plaster, transferred to canvas, 1820–1822; 57½ × 32½ in. The savagery of Saturn (Cronus) expresses Goya's insight into human cruelty and self-destructiveness, themes that dominated his thoughts in his old age. (*Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY*)



no hint of the cannibalism in the myth. The tone of the sculpture is restrained and unemotional; the force of the work comes from the stark contrast between this present, sober moment and the future, violent overthrow of Saturn from the throne on which he now sits so securely. Cronus' impending overthrow is foreshadowed in the image of the proffered swaddled stone. In comparison, Goya's painting, concentrating as it does on the act of cannibalism, exists only in a lurid and nightmarish present, with no hint of resolution. It may effectively be compared with Rubens' *Saturn Devouring His Son*, which may have inspired Goya's work. Goya's painting does not make clear whether Cronus is driven to consume his children in madness or whether the savage necessity of the act has driven him mad. It may express the purely personal loss of many of the painter's own children while they were still young or the brutality of war, particularly when a country murders its own children in civil strife; or perhaps it is a more metaphysical portrait of the ravages of the tyrant Chronos (Time), who feeds on us all.



Rhea Offers the Stone to Cronus. Detail of a large relief, a Roman copy of about A.D. 160 of a Greek original of the fourth century B.C. Rhea, with her veil thrown back (appropriately for a wife approaching her husband), has wrapped the stone as if it were a baby in swaddling clothes. Cronus, seated on a throne and nude from the waist up, reaches out to accept the "baby." The hand above the head of Cronus belongs to another figure in the relief which is not part of this narrative. (Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY)

the father, the essentially sexual nature of love, the terror of castration. The castration complex of the Freudians is the male's unconscious fear of being deprived of his sexual potency, which springs from his feeling of guilt because of his unrecognized hatred of his father and his desire for his mother. Hesiod provides literary documentation for the elemental psychic conscience of humankind. Finally, Hesiod, with characteristic simplicity, suggests Aphrodite's powers of fertility by a brief and beautiful image, "and grass rose under her slender feet."

Is it Hesiod's art that gets to the essence of things, or is it that he is close to the primitive expression of the elemental in human nature? It is commonplace to say that, although elements of the more grotesque myths may be detected in Greek literature, they were humanized and refined by the Greeks and transformed by their genius. Yet it is also true that these primitive elements were retained deliberately and consciously because of the horror, shock, and revelation they contain. The Greeks did not suppress the horrible and horrifying; they selected from it and used it boldly with profound insight and sensitivity. Thus, Hesiod's account may reflect a primitive myth, the ultimate origins of which we can never really know, but his version gives it meaning with an artistry that is far from primitive.

Cronus (Sky) and Rhea (Earth) and the Birth of Zeus

Cronus united with his sister Rhea, who gave birth to Hestia, Demeter, Hera, Hades, Poseidon, and Zeus. Cronus devoured all these children, except Zeus, as Hesiod relates (*Theogony* 459–491):

Great Cronus swallowed his children as each one came from the womb to the knees of their holy mother, with the intent that no other of the illustrious descendants of Uranus should hold kingly power among the immortals. For he learned from Ge and starry Uranus that it was fated that he be overcome by his own child. And so he kept vigilant watch and lying in wait he swallowed his children. (459–467)

A deep and lasting grief took hold of Rhea and when she was about to bring forth Zeus, father of gods and men, then she entreated her own parents, Ge and starry Uranus, to plan with her how she might bring forth her child in secret and how the avenging fury of her father, Uranus, and of her children whom great Cronus of the crooked counsel swallowed, might exact vengeance. And they readily heard their dear daughter and were persuaded, and they counseled her about all that was destined to happen concerning Cronus and his stout-hearted son. And they sent her to the town of Lyctus in the rich land of Crete when she was about to bring forth the youngest of her children, great Zeus. And vast Ge received him from her in wide Crete to nourish and foster. (467–480) 10

Carrying him from Lyctus, Ge came first through the swift black night to Mount Dicte. And taking him in her hands she hid him in the deep cave in the depths of the holy earth on the thickly wooded mountain.¹⁷ And she wrapped up a great stone in infant's coverings and gave it to the son of Uranus, who at 20

A Cretan Hymn to Dictaeon Zeus, Greatest *Kouros* (Youth), Son of Cronus

O Youth, most great,
Hail to you, son of Cronus,
Mighty splendor over all,
Steadfast leader of the gods. . . .

The text goes on to celebrate how the Kouretes (Curetes, Young Men) with their shields received the baby god from Rhea and hid him; the climax of the hymn is a prayer for personal and communal blessings from the young god. The chorus sings and dances to the sound of lyres and oboes around an altar. In the verses, Dicte (Dikta) is the name of the mountain (now called Petsophas) close to Palaikastro in east Crete, where a Minoan palace has been excavated. Here remains of a Greek temple from the seventh century B.C. have been found and also an altar and the stone inscribed with this hymn. The inscription derives from the fourth or third centuries B.C. The age of the cult, however, must go back to the second millennium.

A strong tradition existed (as we have seen in Hesiod) that Zeus was born at Mt. Dicte, where this sanctuary of Zeus Dictaeus (Diktaios) was found (but there is no famous Dictaeon cave). Mount Dicte was confused with Mt. Ida in central Crete with its famous Idaean cave because of a rival tradition that connected Zeus' birth with Mt. Ida. The two versions were reconciled by claiming that Zeus, born on Mt. Dicte, was taken to the Idaean cave on Mt. Ida to be brought up.

Dominant in the hymn is the depiction of Zeus as a young man (*kouros*). Near the archaic sanctuary of Zeus, with its inscription of the hymn, was found a precious chryselephantine statuette of the Minoan Age, the Palaikastro Kouros. The superb workmanship of this beardless young man wrought in precious materials indicates that he must be a god (his body and face carved in ivory, his eyes of crystal, and his belt of gold). Surely this Kouros from the Bronze Age is an earlier conception of the mighty young Greek Zeus of the hymn.¹⁸

that time was the great ruler and king of the gods. Then he took it in his hands, poor wretch, and rammed it down his belly. He did not know in his heart that there was left behind, in the stone's place, his son unconquered and secure, who was soon to overcome him and drive him from his power and rule among the immortals. (481–491)

Cronus and Rhea are deities of sky and earth, doublets of Uranus and Gaea, whose power they usurp, and their union represents the reenactment of the universal sacred marriage. But in the tradition, Cronus and Rhea have a more specific reality than their parents. Cronus appears in art as a majestic and sad deity, sickle in hand. He rules, as we shall see, in a golden age among mortals; and after he is deposed by Zeus, he retires to some distant realm, sometimes designated as the Islands of the Blessed, one of the Greek conceptions of paradise. Cronus is called Saturn by the Romans.

Rhea, too, has a definite mythical personality, although basically she is yet another mother-goddess of earth and fertility. She sometimes is equated with **Cybele**, a Near Eastern goddess whose worship spread to both Greece and, later, Rome; the worship of Rhea-Cybele involved frenzied devotion and elements of mysticism. Her attendants, **Curetes**, played wild music on drums and cymbals, and she was attended by animals. The *Homeric Hymn to the Mother of the Gods* (14) pays tribute to this aspect of Rhea's nature:

Through me, clear-voiced Muse, daughter of great Zeus, sing a hymn to the mother of all gods and all mortals too. The din of castanets and drums, along with the shrillness of flutes, are your delight, and also the cry of wolves, the roar of glaring lions, the echoing mountains, and the resounding forests.

So hail to you and, at the same time, all the goddesses in my song.

The Tradition That Zeus Was Born in Greece, Not in Crete

The tradition was also very strong that Zeus was born in Arcadia in Greece. Callimachus in the opening lines of his first *Hymn to Zeus* expresses his quandary: Should he address the supreme god as lord of Mt. Dicte or Ida in Crete or as lord of Mt. Lycaenum (Greek Lykaion) in Arcadia? He believes, however, that the Cretans are always liars, and he affirms that Rhea gave birth to Zeus in Arcadia, on the mountain, in a holy place, sheltered by very dense brush.

In classical times, Mt. Lycaenum in Arcadia (in the southern Peloponnese) became the site of an important Panhellenic sanctuary of Zeus to rival his more famous one at Olympia (see pp. 118–122), only about 22 miles away. Excavations carried out in the early years of the twentieth century revealed a hippodrome, stadium, xenon (guest house), stoa, monuments, and a bathhouse, testimony to the importance of the Lycaean games.

The traveler Pausanias visited the site (*Description of Greece*, 8.38.2–7), and he tells us that some Arcadians called Mt. Lycaenum Olympus or Sacred Peak because it was on this mountain that Zeus was born; Pausanias names the three nymphs who brought him up. Furthermore, a specific place on the mountain was called Cretea, and Zeus was born here, not in Crete, as the Cretans claim. Most interesting of all is Pausanias' identification of a mound of earth as an altar of Zeus at the highest peak of the mountain, from which most of the Peloponnese could be seen. In front of the altar stood two gilded eagles, and on this altar sacrifices were offered, in secret, to Lycaean Zeus. Unfortunately for those of us who would very much like to know, he did not want to inquire into the nature of these sacrifices but preferred to let them continue, as they were and had been from the beginning, without his prying.

New excavations by a team of archaeologists, both Greek and American (from the Universities of Pennsylvania and Arizona), begun in 2004, offer a thorough reexamination of the site, including the altar of Zeus and its sacred area (temenos), 4,500 feet above sea level and presenting a stunning view. The earlier excavators had unearthed material from the altar, dating no earlier than the seventh century B.C. Exciting new finds include objects from earlier periods, for example, the Mycenaean and before, as far back as the early Bronze Age. Of particular interest

are a rock crystal seal depicting the image of a bull with a full frontal face, a small bronze hand of Zeus holding a silver lightning bolt, and a piece of fulgurite or petrified lightning (a kind of glass formed when lightning strikes loose earth). Many bones were recovered of both large and small animals but none of humans.

It was only fitting that Zeus as a god of thunder and lightning would be worshiped on this stormy mountain peak.

Religious and Historical Views

Of great mythological significance is Hesiod's account of the birth of Zeus on the island of Crete. In this version, we can detect some of the basic motives in the creation of myth, especially when we take into account later variations and additions. From these we learn that after Rhea brought forth Zeus in a cave on Mt. Dicte, he was fed by bees and nursed by nymphs on the milk of a goat named **Amalthea**. Curetes guarded the infant and clashed their spears on their shields so that his cries would not be heard by his father, Cronus. These attendants and the noise they make suggest the frantic devotees of a mother-goddess: Ge, Rhea, or Cybele. The myth is etiological in its explanation of the origin of the musical din and ritual connected with her worship.

Like many myths, the story of the birth of Zeus on Crete accommodates an actual historical occurrence: the amalgamation of at least two different peoples or cultures in the early period. When the inhabitants of Crete began to build their great civilization and empire (ca. 3000), the religion they developed (insofar as we can ascertain) was Mediterranean in character, looking back to earlier Eastern concepts of a mother-goddess. The northern invaders who entered the peninsula of Greece (ca. 2000), bringing with them an early form of Greek and their own gods (chief of whom was Zeus), built a significant Mycenaean civilization on the mainland, but it was strongly influenced by the older, more sophisticated power of Crete. The myth of the birth of Zeus reads very much like an attempt to link by geography and genealogy the religion and deities of both cultures. Zeus, the male god of the Indo-Europeans, is born of Rhea, the Near Eastern goddess of motherhood and fertility.

Two dominant strains in the character of subsequent Greek thought can be understood at least partly in terms of this thesis. W. K. C. Guthrie clearly identifies this dual aspect of the religion of classical Greece in the contrast he makes between the Olympian gods of Homer and the cult of the mother-goddess Demeter at Eleusis:

The Mother-goddess is the embodiment of the fruitful earth, giver of life and fertility to plants, animals and men. Her cult takes certain forms, involving at least the more elementary kinds of mysticism, that is, the belief in the possibility of a union between the worshipper and the object of his worship. Thus the rites may take the form of adoption as her son or of sexual communion. Orgiastic elements appear, as in the passionate, clashing music and frenzied dancing employed by the followers of Rhea or Cybele. . . . What an essentially different atmosphere we are in from that of the religion of the Achaean heroes described by Homer. There we are in clear daylight, in a world where the gods are simply more powerful persons who might fight for or against one, with whom one made bargains or contracts. The Achaean warrior did not seek to be born again from the bosom of Hera. He was indeed the reverse of a mystic by temperament.¹⁹

The Ancient of Days, by William Blake (1757–1827); relief etching printed on paper with hand coloring, 1794, about $9\frac{1}{2} \times 6\frac{1}{2}$ in. The Platonic notion of the Creator as geometer is dramatically expressed by Blake in the frontispiece to his book *Europe: A Prophecy*, printed and published by him at Lambeth in 1794. His Creator is Urizen (the root of whose name is the Greek word meaning “to set limits”), creator of the material world, author of false religions, and tyrant over the human spirit because of his reasoning powers and materialism. By his act of creation, Urizen separated the beings who represent, respectively, the Spirit of Joy and Poetry and the Spirit of Repressive Religion and Law. The compasses derive from Milton’s lines (*Paradise Lost* 7. 225–227: “He took the golden compasses prepar’d/ . . . to circumscribe/This Universe and all created things”): Milton could well have been thinking of Plato’s demiurge (creator). Thus the Greek and biblical myths of the separation of earth and sky, and of the coming of evil, contribute to Blake’s political and religious allegory. (Mortimer Rare Book Room, Smith College, Northampton, MA)



We can detect the ramifications of this paradox again and again in many places in the development of Greek civilization, but perhaps we feel it most clearly in the mysticism and mathematics that permeate Greek philosophical attitudes: the numbers of Pythagoras and the immortality of the soul in Orphic doctrine; the dichotomy of Platonic thought and Socratic character in the search for clarity and definition through rational argument coupled with the sound of an inner voice, the depths of a trance, and divine revelation in terms of the obscure and profound symbols of religious myth. For Plato, God is not only a geometer but also a mystic.²⁰

Mythological Interpretations

Ample material is all too apparent for testing the most persistent of interpretative theories discussed in Chapter 1. Here are myths predominantly about nature that accord with the analysis of Max Müller, although we need not, like Müller, argue that all subsequent mythological stories must be interpreted as allegories of cosmological and natural phenomena.

Feminist concerns are addressed prominently: Mother Earth is the first and most fundamental deity, and the feminine will always remain aggressively

assertive, if not *always* dominant, in Graeco-Roman mythology; but it is encroached upon by masculine conceptions of the divine, as patriarchy in both society and religion gains supremacy, which is not, by any means, always absolute over matriarchy.

Most apparent is the constant interweaving of structuralist motifs. The dualities (binary opposites) of Lévi-Strauss are everywhere: chaos/order, male/female, sky/earth, youth/age, and beauty/ugliness. Psychological and psychoanalytical motifs abound: Freudian sexuality is blatantly manifest in the castration of Uranus, and the subconscious motivations of the psyche reveal themselves in the recurring pattern of the victory of the ambitious son in his battle for power against his ruthless father. The Jungian archetype of the holy marriage that is enacted three times (by Uranus and Gaia, Cronus and Rhea, and finally Zeus and Hera) is equally basic and universal. The characters in these conflicts in the beginning of things are themselves archetypes: earth mother and queen, sky father and king, vying for control and settling for an uneasy and sometimes bitter reconciliation between the sexes.

Above all, these stories are etiological, beautiful and powerful mythical explanations of the origins and nature of the universe and the devastating physical and emotional force of love.

Select Bibliography

See also the Select Bibliography at the end of Chapter 4.

Caldwell, Richard S. *Origins of the Gods: A Psychoanalytic Study of Greek Theogonic Myth*. New York: Oxford University Press, 1993. Identifies aspects of psychoanalytic theory relevant for Greek myth and interprets the themes of origin and success, as found in Hesiod's *Theogony*.

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Kerényi, Carl. *The Gods of the Greeks*. London: Thames and Hudson, 1951.

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Primary Sources

Sources in the Chapter

Euripides	<i>Chrysippus</i> fragment 893
Hesiod	<i>Theogony</i> (selections)
	<i>Works and Days</i> (selections)
Aristophanes	<i>Birds</i> 685–707: Eros and Creation
Homeric Hymn 5	To Aphrodite 220–238
Homeric Hymn 14	To the Mother of the Gods
Homeric Hymn 30	To Earth, Mother of All
Homeric Hymn 31	To Helios
Homeric Hymn 32	To Selene
Ovid	<i>Metamorphoses</i> (selections)

Additional Sources

Apollodorus	<i>Library</i> 1.1.1–1.1.7: Creation
Pausanias	<i>Description of Greece</i> 5.1.3–5.1.5: Endymion
Pindar	<i>Olympian Ode</i> 7.54–74: Helios and the island of Rhodes
Plato	<i>Timaeus</i> 26e–48e: A religious and philosophical discussion of God and the creation of the universe
Strabo	<i>Geography</i> 11.4.7: Selene, priests, and human sacrifice

Notes

1. Perhaps Hesiod may anticipate the pre-Socratic philosophers who sought a primal world substance or substances. Thales (ca. 540) seems to provide a startling break with mythological and theological concepts when he claims that water is the source of everything, with shattering implications for both science and philosophy.
2. We shall use the names Gaia, Gaea, and Ge, which mean “earth,” interchangeably.
3. For the Orphic myth of creation in particular, see pp. 391–392.
4. The concept of god creating something out of nothing is not found in the Greek and Roman tradition.
5. These Cyclopes are distinct from the Cyclops Polyphemus and his fellows.
6. See the bibliography for Iconography, Religion, and Feminist Interpretations in Chapter 1, p. 00. This matriarchal concept belongs to both the matriarchs and the patriarchs; it depends on whose point of view you are talking about.
7. Euripides, *Fragments*, ed. and trans. Christopher Collard and Martin Cropp. Vol. 8 of the Loeb edition of Euripides (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2008), pp. 466–467.
8. Cf. Erich Neumann, *The Great Mother: An Analysis of the Archetype*, 2d ed. (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1963).
9. Indeed, some scholars are ready to find Ge’s presence in every goddess and are deeply suspicious of even the most circumspect virgin deities.
10. Included are many important rivers such as the Nile, Alpheus, and Scamander, to mention only three in this world, and the Styx, an imaginary one in the realm of Hades. The patronymic Oceanid regularly refers to a daughter of Oceanus and not a son.
11. When a Roman version of a myth is recounted, the Roman names of the original text will be used (Vulcan is Hephaestus, Jupiter is Zeus, etc.). For the Roman names of the major Greek deities, see the beginning of Chapter 5, p. 114.
12. His sisters (daughters of the sun), in their mourning for Phaëthon, are turned into trees from whose bark tears flow, which are hardened into amber by the sun and dropped into the river. Away in Liguria his cousin, Cynus, mourns for him, and he too changes and becomes a swan.
13. Rhodes was associated with several figures of saga. From Egypt came Danaüs, who visited the island on his journey to Argos and there founded the great temple of Athena at Lindos. A son of Heracles, Tlepolemus, murdered his uncle Licymnius at Tiryns, and on the advice of Apollo fled to Rhodes. He later led the Rhodian contingent in the Trojan War. Rhodes was also the home of the Telchines, who were skilled craftsmen and metal-workers. They were also credited with having the evil eye; and for this reason (says Ovid), Zeus drowned them in the sea.
14. Artemis, like Selene, as a moon-goddess is associated with magic, since there is a close link between magic and worship of the moon. Apollo and Artemis themselves have a close link with the Titans. The Titan Coeus mated with his sister Phoebe, and their daughter Leto bore Artemis and Apollo to Zeus. Coeus and Phoebe are little more than names to us, but Phoebe is the feminine form of Phoebus, and she herself may very well be another moon-goddess. Hecate, goddess of the moon, ghosts, and black magic, is but another aspect of both Selene and Artemis (see pp. 230–231).